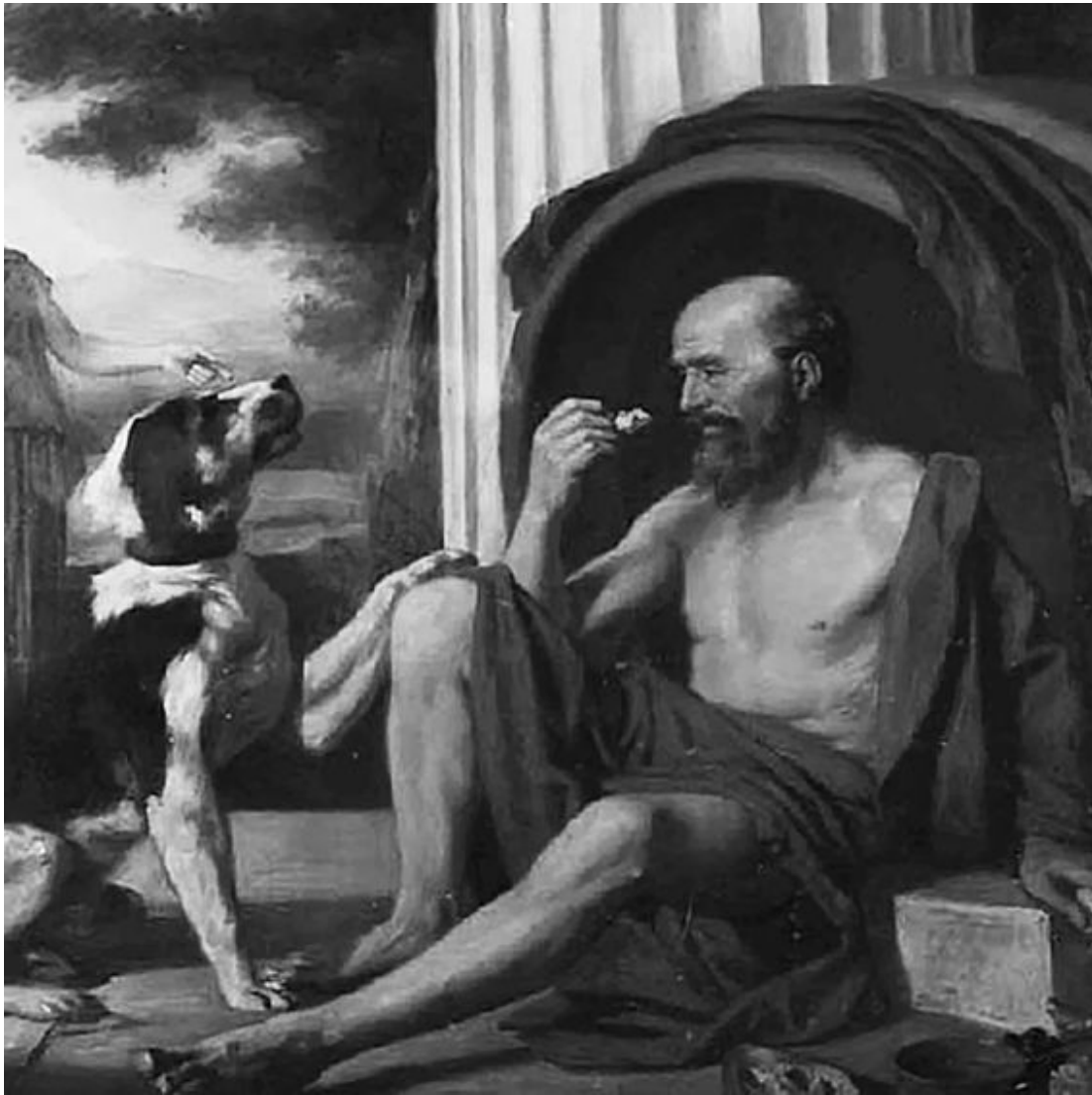


Cynics: Diogenes



The trio of Socrates, Plato and Aristotle proved something of a hard act to follow: after them, Greek philosophy soon divided into four separate schools of thought: the cynics, sceptics, Epicureans and stoics. The cynics followed the thinking – and eccentric lifestyle – of Diogenes of Sinope, who took Socrates's idea of rejecting conventional ideas of virtue to an extreme. Diogenes regarded desires for wealth, power and honour as obstacles to virtue, preventing one from living a good and happy life. Instead, he advocated a simple life, free from material possessions and in harmony with human nature. This was no mere philosophical stance;

Diogenes lived on the streets of Athens with no home except a discarded ceramic tub, wearing rags, scrounging food and ignoring the norms of social custom and etiquette. Like Socrates, he would accost Athenian citizens, but more critically; he was said to carry a lamp even in daylight 'to help him find an honest man'. He was nicknamed 'the Dog' for his lifestyle, and the word *kynikos*, dog-like, was adopted for the school of philosophy he founded.